# EWF Wrestling Manager

## The game today: a full review

Gameplay, systems, stability, balance, screens, code, content and readiness for Steam. Built from the code, the tests, a 60-week run of every company, and screenshots taken at 1920×1080.

17 October 2026 | Version 0.85 | Branch claude/awesome-lovelace-qb0f2j

340 commits since 6 October

## The verdict

**The game is deep, and the simulation is solid.** Few games in this genre have this many interlocking systems: living feuds, a relationship memory, a live show with calls from the gorilla position, the road, the press, the writers' room and post-mortems. The engine is repeatable and well tested.

**The biggest problems are not features.** They are:

- **The default world can't fill a show.** In the parody world, the one a new game starts in, Suggest a card fails for 4 of 9 companies within a year, including EWE, the company you start as.
- **The screens don't use a big screen.** At 1080p they waste space and cut text short.
- **Hard to learn.** The game is deep enough that a new player will struggle to see what matters.

| Area | Grade | In one line |
|---|---|---|
| Depth of the simulation | A | Over 40 systems that feed each other through people and memory. |
| Stability | B | No crashes or bad numbers. 2 old test failures, and the parody card problem. |
| Testing | A- | 41 headless and 38 browser tests, a repeatability check, a build-order check. |
| Balance | C+ | Better since 0.73. The big company is still fired on 2 of 3 runs, and two models go broke. |
| Screens and readability | B- | Clear 90s look that fits. Small text, cut-off lines, empty space at 1080p. |
| Learning the game | C | Many terms (BP, AP, heat, freshness, market) and little guided teaching. |
| Code health | B | Clear rules and hooks. Very dense lines, one shared scope, some files getting big. |
| Content and legal | B | Two original worlds and a parody disclaimer. No licence chosen; old notes still in git history. |
| Ready for Steam | C | Plays in a browser today. The wrapper, store page, achievements and settings still need work. |

## The game in numbers

**84**
engine files, about 13,000 lines (1.2 MB of code)

**86**
screen files, about 7,700 lines

**79**
automated tests (41 headless, 38 browser)

**2.4 MB**
the whole game in one HTML file

**1.5 s**
from opening the page to a playable desk

**2**
worlds: parody (9 companies) and public domain

**135 / 240**
items done in TASKS.md (105 open)

**100 / 100**
TWEAKS done; WISHLIST 100 of 101 done

## What the player does

A week has three parts, and each hands the next something unresolved:

| Phase | What happens | What it hands on |
|---|---|---|
| **The Office** | The desk shows the road (the city, the building, tickets sold), matters to answer, this week's tasks and the next show. Backstage is people who need you, each with a file and a memory of you. Storylines holds living feuds and the plot actions you can spend booking power on. | A fire with a deadline, and people in a mood. |
| **Booking** | Fill two or three hours with matches, promos and angles. The road agent reads each match without saying too much. Running order, chemistry, fatigue and promises all matter. | A card with visible risks. |
| **The Show** | Played on the air step by step. The gorilla position takes calls: injuries, a quiet crowd, the owner, the network, sponsors, and now trouble in the building. Then After the show gives the grade, the verdict and what the night left behind. | A new problem or chance for next week. |

## The systems

| Group | Systems |
|---|---|
| People | Relationship matrix and memories, backstage as people, dossiers, requests at your door, scenes between two people, mood, stress, the locker room, the mutiny clock, teachers and students, a champion's friends, hometowns. |
| Stories | Living feuds (heat and freshness), story sifting, company arcs, debuts, battle royals, the writers' room, promo words written from real history. |
| The show | The live show and calls, the running order, the show clock, segments, fog of war and the road agent, card flags, venues and disasters. |
| Business | The road with markets and ticket sales, TV shows with standing and deals, network tastes and executives, streaming, sponsors, contracts with clauses, cancellation, big events with names, head-to-head nights. |
| The world | Rival companies, invasions and working deals, shows and belts made during a game, a world's history, the press and leaks (kayfabe), post-mortems, archived career saves. |
| Tools | The World Editor, the logo creator, scenarios as data, two built-in worlds, modding documents. |

> **Watch:** each new system adds calls, matters and notes, and they all compete for the same desk. Without a rule for how many interruptions a week may carry, the game risks feeling busy rather than deep.

## Stability and tests

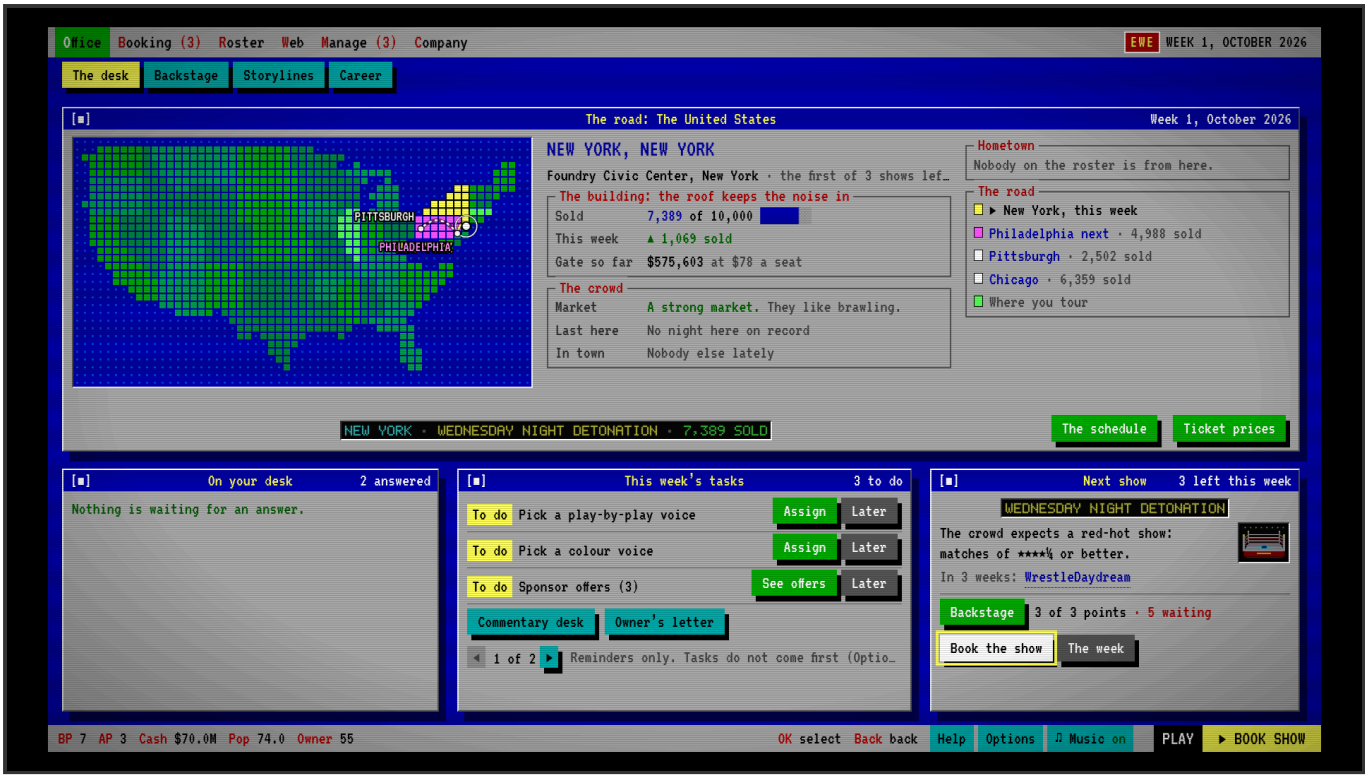
| Check | Result | Notes |
|---|---|---|
| Headless test suite (41) | **39 / 41** | **test-cancel:** a strong run of house shows no longer brings a network offer. **test-events:** no tournament winner is promised the flagship. Both were already failing before this week's changes. |
| Same seed, same game | **Pass** | Every game can be replayed exactly. |
| No dice wording | **Pass** | 60 weeks of text checked. |
| Public-domain world, 60 weeks | **Pass** | No errors, no bad numbers. |
| Parody world (the default), 60 weeks | **4 fail** | Suggest a card leaves an invalid card for EWE, AYY, CALL and ARK between weeks 48 and 60. No crashes or bad numbers, but **the starting company cannot always book itself.** |
| Main pages at 1920×1080 | **Pass** | Desk, Backstage, Storylines, Booking, Roster, Overview, Web and Manage all fit without scrolling. No console errors. |

## Balance

From the 100-week balance runs on suggested cards (docs/balance-0.73.txt):

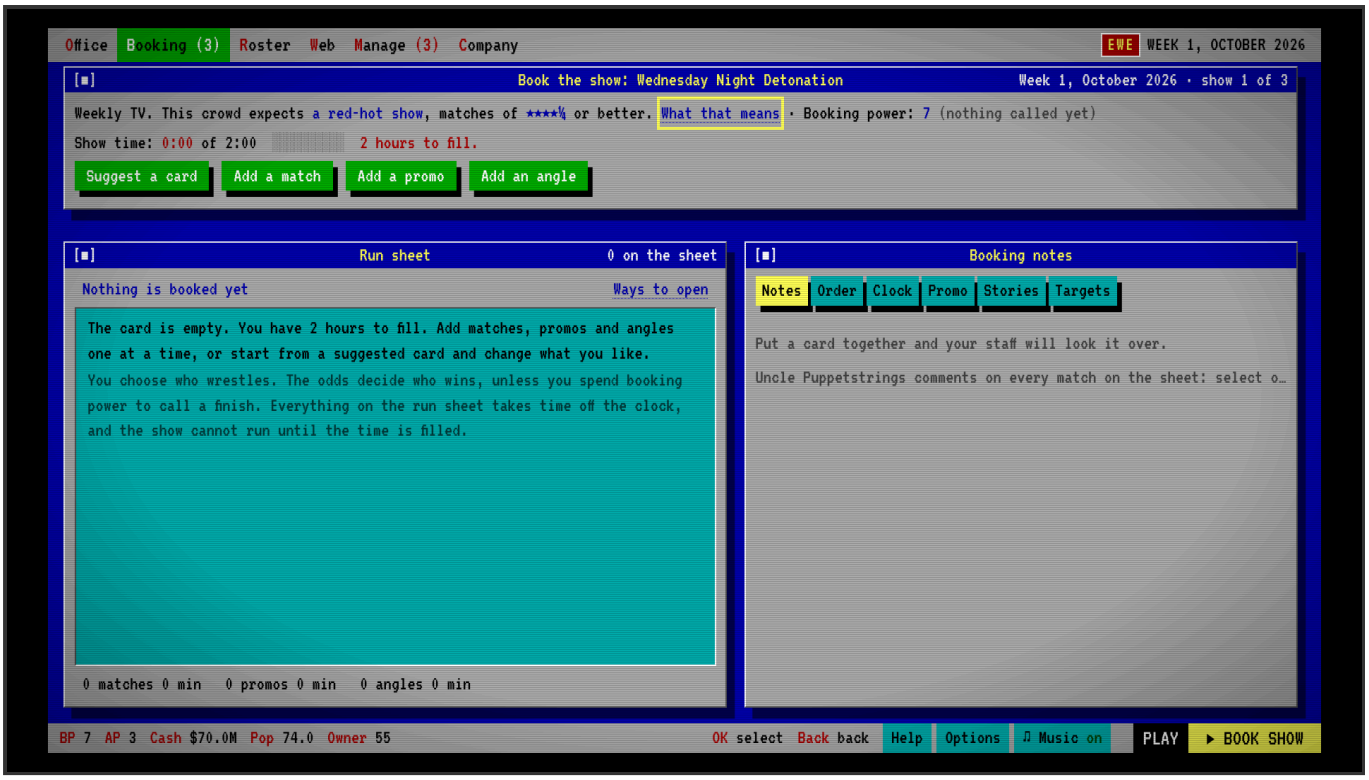
- **Better:** the giant no longer grows to $400M. The underdog survives 100 weeks on all three seeds. The mutiny meeting no longer comes back every few weeks.
- **Still off:** the giant's booker is fired on 2 of 3 seeds. The workrate and outlaw companies go broke on one seed each. The startup is too easy once it gets a better TV slot (about +$470K a week).
- **Crowd against expectation** sits below zero for every company (−0.05 to −1.84). Suggested cards rarely please a crowd, so the player's own booking has room to shine. Too far below and the game feels harsh.

## The screens at 1080p




The desk at 1920×1080, parody world, week 1.

- **Works:** the road window is the clear centre, the dot map reads at a glance, the ticker in lights gives the show presence, and the SPACE key always says what's next.
- **Wasted space:** a black border around the whole page (the TV safe area), an empty band under the road window, and "On your desk" mostly empty when nothing waits.
- **Cut-off text:** "the first of 3 shows lef…" and "Reminders only. Tasks do not come first (Optio…". Lines that cut off at 1080p will cut off more at 720p.
- **Weak contrast:** the sold bar is dark blue on grey, and the red first letters in the menu are hard to read.




Book the show, before anything is booked.

- **Empty state:** two thirds of the screen is an empty teal box and an empty notes pane. The best first move, Suggest a card, is one small button among four.
- **Wording:** "The odds decide who wins" sits close to the no-dice rule. Words like "the attempt" or "how the match plays out" fit the game's own language better.




The roster: 75 under contract, 15 to a page.

- **Bars without meaning:** Crowd, Mood and Body are nearly all full green, so the table doesn't help you compare. A short word or a wider range of colour would.

- **Contrast:** a yellow "Stable" tag on the green picked line can't be read. The picked row's bars turn white.
- **Room:** at 1080p there's space for 20 or more rows instead of 15. The Brand column is almost always empty.

## Learning the game

- **Words a new player must learn early:** BP, AP, heat, freshness, market, standing, crowd score, booking power, action points, attempts. The bottom line uses the short forms.
- **Help exists** (F1, the owner's letter, required first-year actions) but it's text-heavy. Nothing walks a new player through the first week by doing it.
- **Suggestion:** a guided first week. The owner's letter points to the desk, the desk to Backstage, then Suggest a card, the show and After the show, each with one sentence and a highlighted button.

## Code health

| Strength | Detail |
|---|---|
| Clear rules | The engine owns the game, screens never write to the state, hooks for every system, CLAUDE.md as a map. |
| Repeatable | A seeded generator and hashes, so saves and bug reports can be replayed. |
| Checked order | A test now makes sure a file that wraps another's functions loads after it. |

| Risk | Detail |
|---|---|
| Very dense code | 13,000 lines hold 1.2 MB, about 90 characters a line, and 166 lines run past 300 characters. That's hard for a person to read or review, and diffs are hard to follow. |
| One shared scope | Every engine file shares one closure, and later files rewrite earlier functions. It's powerful, but the more wraps there are, the harder it is to know what a function does. |
| Hooks everywhere | Many systems push onto the same weekly and show hooks. The order they run in is the file order, which is easy to break by renaming a file. |
| Save size | About 1.2 MB a save after 100 weeks. The yearly archive keeps 30 years near 3 MB. |

## Content and legal

- **Two worlds:** parody (the default since 16 October) and public domain, plus a World Editor and modding guide.
- **Open:** no licence chosen (decisions-needed.md lists four options). The notes on who each parody character is were moved out of the repository, but **git history still holds them**. Removing them means rewriting history, which is Ryan's call.
- **Before release:** have the lawyer review the parody world and the disclaimer once more against the final names.

## Ready for Steam?

| Item | State | Notes |
|---|---|---|
| Runs on desk, tablet, TV | Yes | Tested at three sizes. Keyboard, mouse, touch and gamepad. |
| Saves | Mostly | IndexedDB with a backup copy. A desktop build should save to files the player can see and back up. |
| Desktop wrapper | Started | An Electron package exists at the root. Not part of the test runs. |
| Licence, credits, store page | No | Needed before release. |
| Achievements, cloud saves | No | Optional, but expected by Steam players of management games. |

## What to do, in order

| # | Do this | Why |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | **Fix Suggest a card in the parody world** | It's the default world and the starting company. A player who leans on suggestions hits an invalid card within a year. |
| 2 | **Fix the two failing tests** | Small, and keeps the test suite trusted. |
| 3 | **Ryan picks the new desk look and the 1080p approach** | Design at 1080p and let the existing type-size setting scale down to 1280×720. |
| 4 | **A readability pass on every one-screen page** | No cut-off lines, no empty bands, words beside every colour, bigger bars that differ. |
| 5 | **A guided first week** | The depth is there; new players need a path into it. |
| 6 | **A limit on interruptions a week** | So new systems add depth, not noise. Rank matters and calls, show the top few, and let the rest wait. |
| 7 | **Finish the add-ons run** | Phase 3: supercards, academy, dynasties. Phase 4: match viewer, sound, leagues, play as a wrestler. |
| 8 | **Balance pass** | The giant's firing rate, the two companies that go broke, the startup's easy money. |
| 9 | **Release groundwork** | Licence, credits, desktop saves to files, wrapper in the test runs, store page. |
| 10 | **Code readability, a little each week** | Break the longest lines when a file is touched anyway. No big rewrite. |

## Decisions for Ryan

- Which desk look, and design at 1080p while keeping 1280×720 working?
- A guided first week: yes or no?
- A cap on interruptions each week: how many calls and matters?
- Licence: which of the four options?
- Rewrite git history to remove the old parody notes?
- Publish the add-ons work to the live page now, or after the run?

Sources: the repository at version 0.85, the headless suite, a 60-week run of every company in both worlds, docs/balance-0.73.txt, TASKS.md, docs/decisions-needed.md, and screenshots taken in Chromium at 1920×1080. Concept art for the redesign: claude.ai/artifact/9vtkC1f1mzGnv866j99xbc.